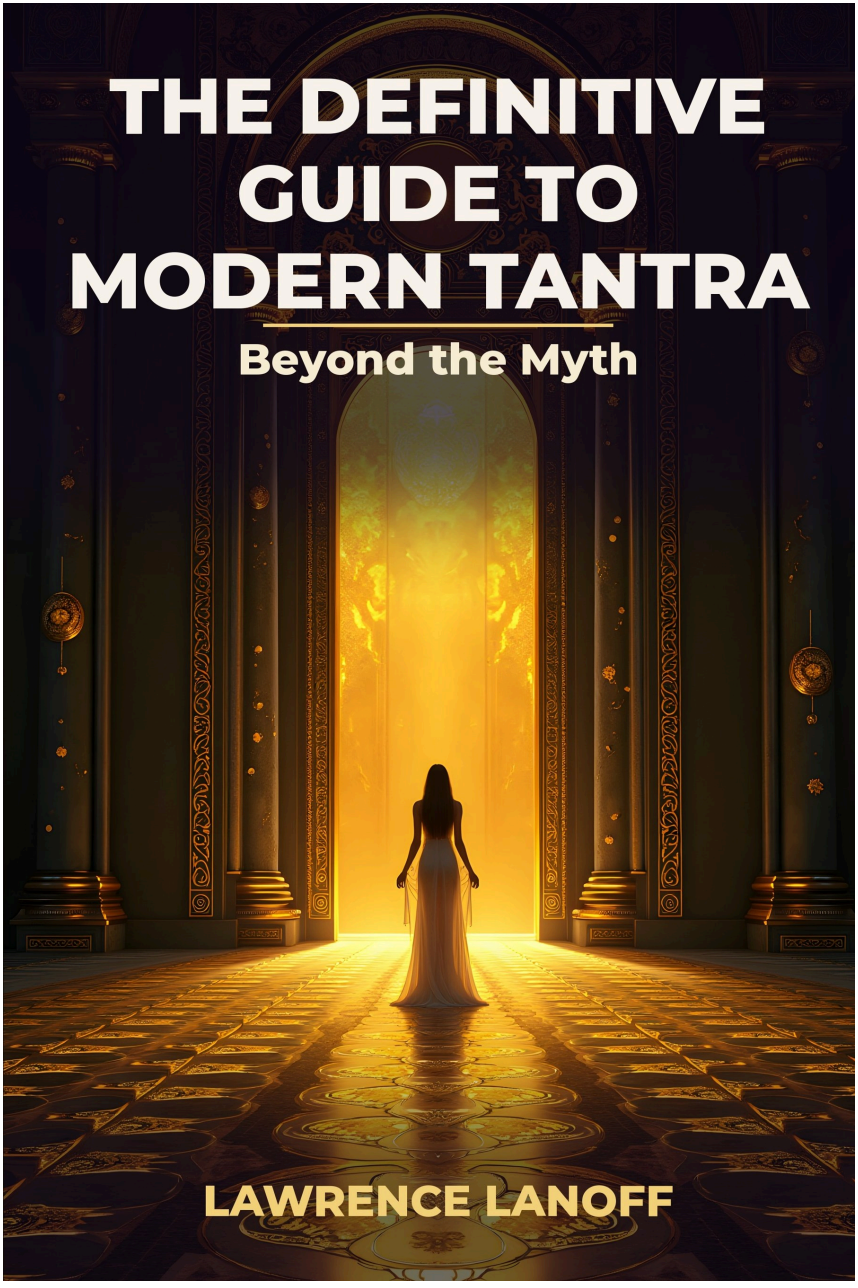

THE DEFINITIVE GUIDE TO MODERN TANTRA
Beyond the Myth
LAWRENCE LANOFF

Free excerpt — Foreword through Chapter 1
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Foreword

I am nobody. I have no titles. No lineage authorizing me. No certificate to make me look legitimate. I grew up in the West Village of New York City. There was a lot of crazy going on at that time. When I was ten, I started a meditation group. It met every week. Grown adults kept showing up. And one of those nights a tantra teacher walked in — a man who had been raised in the jungles of South America, the one my mother had already told me I needed to study with. He loved what he saw. He was the kind of madman you only meet a few times in a life. And he said it straight to me: you gotta learn this. You gotta learn how to control your orgasm. You gotta learn how to control your sexual energy. I did not know what an orgasm was. I had to look it up in the encyclopedia. That's the guy I ended up studying with. My understanding of sexual energy, clarity and tantra started there. What follows is what one body has learned in decades of practice — with teachers I followed and teachers I left, with lovers, with books, with vipassana retreats and yoga retreats, and decades of work towards alleviating trauma in the body. Some of what I learned was useful. Most of it was not. Much of it was wrong. I have changed my mind. About many things, many times. Until, one day, I touched a grounded truth. People have called what I experienced enlightenment. I call it clarity. No myth, no story, no cult, no group, no belief system, no religion can contain infinitely expanding life. All of them fail, at some point. That is reality. That is the clarity. However, some things persist. This book hands you what persists. Hard-won. Tried on the body. Willingness to be wrong. Willingness to let everything go. Like the sunrise and the sunset. Principles around tantra, the body, and sex outlast every myth, religion, belief system, or group that has ever tried to contain them. The only

requirement from you is willingness to be open. To try things on. I live in the constant unknown. That is where my teachings flow from. To take them in, you will need to be open to being open. Come in.

Author’s Statement

What follows is what I have to offer. Take what works. Leave the rest. Follow the butterflies.

Go Look at the Stars

If you want to understand tantra, go look at the stars. Find the darkest location you can, preferably on a night with no moon, and look up. Breathe. Let it in. Breathe again. Relax into the magnificence of the infinite universe before you. Let that power fill your essence. Breathe from the crown of your head to your toes, and listen. Listen to your body. Listen to the universe. Listen to the darkness of space. Open your belly. Relax your genitals. And listen. Feel. Expand. Breathe. That's the first exercise. That is tantra. And that's the book. Everything else that follows is just details that overlay the silence of an infinitely expanding universe — expanding, infinitely. If you give yourself the space, the time to breathe deeply, the quiet, the darkness, your nervous system will recalibrate. Slowly at first. Then eventually, fully. The body feels the expansiveness of the universe, even when the mind dissociates. The mind will tell you your problems are big, your traumas are overwhelming, your situation is hopeless. But the body, resonating with the infinite universe, knows that your problems are small. Problems are at one scale. The infinite universe is at a completely different scale. There is no comparison. And the mind can't argue with what the body is experiencing in the quiet. This is not a metaphor for the teachings of tantra. This is the teaching of tantra, in the most direct form I know. Tantra is supposed to be about sex. But underneath the sex — the actual subject of this book — is the question that the infinite universe asks of your body. The question is: how do you want to spend the very short time you have? If you've been waiting for permission to live, the night sky, the galaxy, the infinitely expanding universe is your permission. If you've been waiting for someone to tell you that you are allowed to want, to have needs and desires, that it is okay for you to want what you

want — then the night sky is the true authority, and it doesn't care what you do. If you've been worrying about whether you've done your life right, the sky does not care. Now — the sky doesn't care is not the same as do whatever you want. You technically can do whatever you want, for about five seconds, until the rest of reality answers back. The sky is indifferent. The stars are indifferent. The eight billion other people on this planet are indifferent — except when it comes to sex. That's when the entire world, one way or another, is concerned about what you do with your genitals. That's the programming anybody with a body has been exposed to. Walk into the world angry, you find an angry world; walk in afraid, the world has teeth; walk in needing the universe to owe you something, you find a universe that owes you nothing. That, also, is tantra. The first half of the work is what just happened with the sky. The second half is one question. The sky owes you nothing. That indifference is the gift. It is the precondition for actual freedom. A universe that is monitoring your genitals would be a pretty fucking dumb universe — a universe I wouldn't want to live in. The universe you actually live in is not monitoring your genitals at all. It's busy making stars and eating them, on a scale where every human life since the first one is but a single letter in a single sentence in an infinite book that the universe is neither reading nor writing. Once this lands, the body can relax. The universe does not care what you do. I always wanted to have sex when I was younger. I couldn't wait. That sense is still present with me. And I hope the "How awesome is this experience" stays until my last breath. That's not a teaching. That's the thread. The body has known the whole time about pleasure and freedom. But we just have to claim it. If we don't claim it, it is guaranteed that someone else will. Some man, some woman, some group, some cult, some belief system, some guru — somewhere along the line — will claim your pleasure and freedom. That is also the reality of reality. So go now. Discover your pleasure. Claim your pleasure. Claim your freedom. This

is where we begin. You can stop here, or you can take the next step with me.

Energy Is Just Energy

Before the breath, the touch, the practices, the history — one principle: energy is energy. Simple. Not masculine energy, not feminine energy, not divine energy, not sacred energy, not evil, not wrong. Nor is it any other label we can possibly create. There are no labels for energy that can contain the boundlessness of the infinite energy that the universe produces. And the energy that flows through the sexual chakras is one of the most feared things on the planet. But it's just energy. And sex energy specifically is the call to life, the call to aliveness, the call to freedom, the call to awakening, the call to expansion. The charge that moves through you when you want someone. The heat up the spine. The pull toward a body across the room, the flush, the ache, the wanting that wakes you at three in the morning. That is energy. It has no morality. Not good or bad, dirty or holy, dark or sacred. It moves through a body. Then you decide what to do with it. I can tell you this from the inside, not just as a claim. In thousands of hours of meditation — sitting in direct exploration of the inner universe — I have never once found a distinction between masculine energy and feminine energy. Not once. Whatever that distinction is, it wasn't in the energy I was sitting with — which tells me it got added, same as every other line ever drawn on top of it. Energy is just energy. Like the sun. Like electricity. Not good, not bad. What you do with it is entirely on you — and learning what to do with it is the actual purpose of this whole practice: harness it, direct it, use it. Everything else — the good, the bad, the dirty, the sacred — got added later. By culture. By the people who needed your energy pointed where they wanted it pointed. They looked at the most powerful current that runs through a human body, and they did the one thing that hands you control over another person: they told you some of it was wrong.

They drew lines on it. This movement is allowed; that one is sin. This wanting is love; that one is filth. None of those lines are in the energy. Every one of them was drawn on top of it. In your actual life, it works like this. Energy wants to move. That's its nature — forward, through, out. When it moves, you feel it as aliveness. Vitality. The thing that makes a person magnetic, awake, lit from the inside. And when it's blocked — shamed and dammed and told to sit still and be good — it doesn't disappear. It can't. It backs up. And backed-up energy has a name in the modern world. We call it depression. We call it numbness. We call it the gray flat nothing so many people live inside of and can't explain. So watch what this does to the whole picture. Every sexual mythology you've ever been handed — every rule about what's clean and what's shameful, what a good woman does, what a real man is, where God supposedly drew the line on your body — every one of them is, underneath, a machine for blocking energy. That's the function. Not the stated purpose — the function. And the cost of that machinery is written on the faces of the people running it: tired, shut down, leaking the very thing they were told to contain. This book is going to take those machines apart, one at a time. Not to hand you better rules. To get the energy moving again. Because there was never anything wrong with the energy. There was only ever something built on top of it — intended to block it, to repress it, to stop it. Energy that's allowed to move is never the danger. The only danger is energy that's stuck. Repressed. Hidden. That is the ground. Everything else follows from it.

A Note Before We Begin — All of Your Emotions Are Welcome

This is a book about the body, and the body, when it finally lets go, doesn't only let go of tension. Sometimes everything comes up with it. So, at the door: All of your emotions are welcome here. If something in these pages moves you and the tears come — they're welcome. If you find yourself laughing at a thing that isn't funny, or shaking, or gone suddenly quiet and tender for no reason you can name — all of it is welcome. The body that's been holding itself together for a long time will, given half a chance and a little safety, start to set things down. What it sets down can look like a lot. Crying. Trembling. A wave of feeling with no story attached to it. None of that is a sign something's wrong. It's the sign the body trusted the room enough to open. You don't have to manage any of it. You don't have to understand it, or explain it, or hold it back to keep reading. Whatever rises, let it rise. Let it move. Then turn the page when you're ready. There is nothing you can feel, reading this, that isn't welcome here. Come in.

The Great Spiritual Question

The core question of building the life you want: What do I want? That's it. The rest of the book is how you find out — and what you do once you know. If you pay attention to your whole body, you'll notice the question is harder than it looks. Most people can answer with what they "should" want — they have a hundred ready answers downloaded from their culture, their parents, their religion, their friends, their feed. What I want, what someone like me is supposed to want, what a good person wants, what a successful person wants. That whole stack of answers is somebody else's. It's not the question. The real question goes deeper. It goes to the version of you lying awake at three AM. The you who lies awake, filled with anxiety, loneliness, guilt, shame, fear, doubt, worry — what does that YOU really want? What are you most afraid of? What do you keep almost-saying but never say? What do you want that you're too embarrassed to admit? Those are the questions that matter. If you're not willing to think dirty about what you actually want, you're never going to get where you're going. The shadow you're not allowed to want is part of the answer. The kink you're embarrassed by is part of the answer. The thing you don't tell anyone is part of the answer. You don't have to do anything about any of it. You just have to be willing to ASK. The body is wired for pleasure. You have an organ — the clitoris, if you have one — that exists for one purpose. Pleasure. That's it. The body is also wired to feel — through the skin, through the breath, through the cock, through every part of itself. The whole thing is built for it. So when the old story says pleasure has to be earned, or that wanting it needs an excuse, or that you should want something else instead — that story isn't morality talking. That's a script arguing with the body. And the body is going to win. What you were probably taught by mommy

and daddy about pleasure may or may not be right. The body is the audit. If it lights up, the body votes yes. If it goes flat, the body votes no. You don't get to overrule it for long. You get to listen. Why does the question matter so much? Because without it, you don't move. Imagine an airplane sitting on the runway with no pilot. The engines might start. The plane might roll forward a little. But it's not going anywhere. It has no destination. It will sit there or veer off the tarmac and stop. What you want is the destination. It doesn't mean you're going to get there. It doesn't mean the universe owes you to get there. But it puts the pilot in the seat. It gives you a heading. It starts you in motion. Curiosity. Desire. What do I want? That's what desire is — it's not just sexual longing. Desire is the engine of asking what you want, the body's information about what it wants, the inside voice that knows what would make you feel alive. People who feel dead inside are usually people who stopped asking the question. Either because the world punished them for the answers, or because they stopped trusting their own inside voice, or because someone trained them out of asking. Whatever the reason. They stopped, and motion stopped, and life flattened into doing what's expected. Asking the question turns the engine back on. That's all. You're going to be off course almost the whole time. A flight from Los Angeles to Hawaii is off course something like ninety-eight percent of the time. The plane is in the wrong heading, drifting in the wind, fighting the jet stream, off by a few degrees here, a few degrees there. The pilot is constantly making small corrections. Adjust. Adjust. Adjust. The plane lands in Hawaii not because it stayed perfectly on course, but because the pilot kept redirecting toward what it wanted — the runway at Honolulu. Your life is that flight. You will be off course almost the whole time. Distracted. Tired. Misled. Wrong-turned. Heartbroken. Confused. The work is not staying on course. The work is redirect, redirect, redirect. You ask what you want. You move toward it. You drift. You ask again. You correct. You move again. The destination keeps you oriented. The corrections

are the practice. This is calibration. It's the second half of the sky-doesn't-care equation. The sky's indifference gives you the freedom to choose your destination at all. Your willingness to keep asking and keep redirecting is what gets you there — most of the time, eventually, with small corrections, none of them perfect. The adult move is discovering how to hold all of it. Make space for all of it. Trauma. Beliefs. Trainings. Identities. The myths you inherited that don't fit anymore. The stories that still half-work. The triumphs you're proud of. The tragedies you're still in. All the shit, too. And prodigious amounts of pleasure. That is Tantra too: ask, redirect, hold the whole thing. The dirty answers and the pleasure answers and the embarrassing answers and the answers you don't tell anyone — they're all part of the destination. The question is honest enough to include them. When you see the bees moving from flower to flower — what they're doing is fucking. When you see the trees doing whatever they do at the level you can't see — fucking. Fuck is what created you. Fuck built the cities. Fuck moves the people who built the cities to keep building. Fuck drives armies. Fuck drives wars. Fuck drives the world. The big lie is that everybody's going to tell you that's not a good thing. They're going to tell you to control it, suppress it, repress it, hide it, shame it. None of that is for your benefit. That is so you don't recognize your own power. So: what do you want? The rest of this book is what you do once you know.

OPEN — The Framework

Listening is the field of awareness. Inside the field, two bodies still have to know what they're doing. There's a moment at the start of every new encounter, wherever it's happening, when both bodies freeze. The conversation goes a little flat. One person reaches for their drink. The other looks at the napkin. The thing that was supposed to be happening is not yet happening. The scripts the culture handed you for this moment — the charming one, the good listener, the mysterious one, the just-friends, the cool-modern-adult — are all performances. The body knows it before you do. This isn't a man script or a woman script. It isn't a straight one either. Two women meeting. Two men. A woman and a man. Any configuration of bodies you want to name — everybody in the room is running the same negotiation, trying to work out the roles and the goals without ever saying so out loud. That's the stress underneath the freeze. Not one body performing at another. Two bodies, each carrying a script, each trying to read the other's script before showing their own. The frames are how you get through life. They are not how you get to another person. Tantra is about the other thing. Connection. Depth. You need a different move. Not a line. A protocol. I'm going to give you the one I use. It has four corners. It sits inside a circle. The circle is the listening from the last chapter. The square is the four corners of what gets said and done inside the listening. The whole shape is what makes the start of an encounter actually openable instead of a thing both bodies are surviving. The acronym is OPEN. O — Own your paradox. You are not one thing. Nobody is. You are, at the same time, the version of you that's been hurt, the version that's done some hurting, the version that wants to be good, the version that wants to be bad, the version that's been waiting for this moment, the version that's

terrified of this moment, the version that knows what you want, the version that has no idea what you want. All of those are true. Don't pick one for the encounter and pretend the others aren't in the room. They're in the room. They came in with you. Owning the paradox is the move where you say, out loud or in your body, I'm here as the whole thing. Not as the cleaned-up dating-profile version. Not as the spiritual-evolved version. Not as the I-have-my-shit-together version. As the actual stack of contradictions that walked through the door. Two adults who can both do this make a different room than two adults who are each performing a single curated version of themselves. The first room can hold what's about to happen. The second can't. You go first. Whichever one of you is more willing to own the paradox goes first. The other body relaxes when you go first, because the first owned paradox in a room gives every other body permission. P — Permission. Whatever they're carrying — they're carrying it. The shame, the history, the heat, the kink they haven't said, the fear they haven't named, the wanting they've been told is too much. Your move is to welcome the whole being. You don't have to know what's in it. You don't have to fix any of it. You don't have to perform unconditional acceptance. You just have to be the body in the room that's not going to add to their pile. Permission sounds like: whatever you're carrying, bring it. Whatever you want, want it. Whatever you're afraid of, the fear is welcome here. We don't have to do anything with any of it. It just gets to come in the room with you. You can say it. Most of the time you don't have to. The permission lands through your posture, your breath, the way you don't flinch when they say something they expected you to flinch at, the way you don't reach for the script when they break the script. Permission is the second corner because most people have never had it. Permission is what unfreezes the bridge problem. The freeze is the body waiting to be judged. Permission tells the body the judge isn't in the room. E — Expectations. The honest deal. Mutual. The culture's version of this corner is figured-out-from-context-clues — what they didn't say, the

body language, the read of the room. Two bodies running different scripts arrive at a mismatch. The fix is direct. Here's what I want. Here's what I don't want. Here's what I can offer. Here's what I'm not offering. What do you want? Where, if anywhere, is our overlap, our meeting point? You can do this in a sentence. You can do this in ten minutes. The length doesn't matter. The honesty matters. Most people are not used to this and will be relieved by it inside about thirty seconds. The thirty seconds before the relief is when the second body realizes you actually mean it. You can wait the thirty seconds out. If the deal is incompatible, you found that out before anybody got hurt — before heavy emotional paperwork. That's a win. The incompatible-deal conversation is also a kind of intimacy — two adults being honest about what they want is closer to each other than two adults pretending. You walk away from the table closer than you came to it, even if you walk away. If the idea is compatible, you now have the beginning of the shared experience. Everything that happens next happens inside the experience. The creation of that space is what makes the rest of the evening a more safe space to explore. N — Navigate. Three things. Breath. When anything in the encounter gets confusing — when you lose the thread, when you can't tell what you want, when you can't read what they want, when the room feels weird — drop into the breath. One slow inhale, one slower exhale. The body settles. The next move becomes available. Most encounters get strangled inside a moment of confusion neither body knew how to walk through. The breath is what walks you through it. You don't have to fill the pause. Being relaxed in the silence is its own kind of beautiful — it's part of what OPEN is training, as much as any of the four corners. Hell yes or no. The threshold. If it isn't a hell yes, it's a no. Any tepid yes — I guess so, sure why not, I don't want to disappoint you, I'll go along with it — is a no in costume. Both bodies need to be at hell yes for the move to be a real move. Tepid yes degrades the encounter for both people. The encounter sourced from two hell-yeses is at a different voltage than any encounter sourced from anything

below a high quality yes. Stop signals. Either body can stop, slow down, change direction, at any moment, no reason required, no explanation owed. The stop is a real position and the freedom to stop is what makes the going-forward worth anything. Red — full stop. Yellow — slow, more breath, more space. Green — continue, deepen. Use the actual words if the words help. Use breath and body if breath and body are clearer. You can use taps if words are not available. 1 tap = green, 2 taps = yellow, 3 taps or more = red, full stop. Breath when confused. Hell yes or else no. Stop signals available always. Three moves, and the encounter has a path forward. A square inside a circle. The circle is listening. The four corners of the square are Own your paradox, Permission, Expectations, Navigate. The square has no top or bottom corner that's more important than the others. You enter through whichever corner the encounter is asking for. Sometimes you enter through Permission because the other body is carrying something heavy. Sometimes you enter through Expectations because the deal needs to get clean before anything else can happen. Sometimes Own your paradox is the only corner that lets the conversation start at all. The shape doesn't care which corner you enter. The shape cares that all four corners are operating before the encounter is allowed to go anywhere serious. The inner layer. Underneath the protocol, there are three hypnotic moves I deploy at the moment of touch. I'm naming them so the body of whoever is reading this can use them too. You don't have to remember the names. You let the images do the work. Magnet. Two bodies a few inches apart, not touching. Eyes closed if you can. The skin feels the other skin without contact. You wait for the pull. The bodies come together because they want to, not because either body decided. The first contact is the magnet completing. Sail unfurling. Once the contact lands, both bodies expand outward. Chest open. Shoulders back. Belly soft. The fabric of you unrolling in the breeze the encounter is making. Bodies that try to contain themselves at first contact freeze the contact. Bodies that unfurl let the contact go where it wants. Flower opening.

Touch arrives at any part of the body. The body's job is to open at the point of contact. Not flinch closed. Not perform receiving. Open. Like a flower receiving the sun. The image is doing the work the conscious mind would otherwise spend an hour negotiating. These are not techniques to perform. They are images to let the body inherit. You hold the image; the body does what the image describes; you stay out of the way. OPEN — Own your paradox, Permission, Expectations, Navigate. Four corners. Square inside the circle. Listening holds them. Hell yes or no, the gate at the threshold. Magnet, sail, flower, at the moment of touch. Use it at dinner or in bed; with somebody you have known ten years or somebody you met an hour ago. Time does not matter. Whether the four corners are operating does. If they are, the encounter can go anywhere. If they're not, no amount of technique in the rest of this book is going to compensate. OPEN is the first move — before anything else gets to start.

Emergence

Notice this. The best sex you've ever had — close your eyes for a second and find it — you didn't plan it. You didn't choreograph it. You may have set the conditions, made the invitation, lit the candles. But the actual encounter — what happened between the bodies — none of you wrote it. It wrote itself out of the space you created together. It looked, after the fact, like it was meant to be. It was not meant. There was no choreographer, though there may be some choreography. And also — given everything that was in the room, in the co-created space, given the histories and the bodies and the mood and the breath and the song that was playing — it could not have happened any other way. Both true. This is emergence. Emergence is what complex systems do. You can describe every water molecule and not predict a wave. You can describe every bird and not predict the flock turning together at sunset. You can describe every neuron and not predict the thought that just arrived in you. Something happens that the parts don't contain. Something arrives that nobody designed. Sex is like that. So is dancing. So is the conversation that turns out to be the most important one you ever had with somebody. So is the fire that catches between two people and burns far hotter than the wood either of them brought. The encounter writes itself out of what's already in the room. Your body. Their body. Your history. Their history. The day. The hour. The mood. The food. The argument you didn't have. The thing you didn't say. The way they laughed at something an hour ago. The smell of their skin. The cosmic temperature of the moment. All of it goes in. The encounter comes out. You didn't write it. You couldn't have written it. The encounter is bigger than what any one body brought into the room. Most adults try to write the encounter anyway. They show up with a script. The script came

from their imagination, from the porn they've watched, from their previous sex, from their fear, from their wanting-to-be-good-at-this. They run the script over the actual moment. The actual moment refuses. They run the script harder. The moment becomes the resistance instead of the gift. What they get is the script. Or worse — a degraded version of the script, because the moment kept refusing, and the fighting drained the field dry. What they could have had was the emergent thing. The thing that was actually trying to happen. They missed it. They were too busy enforcing what they'd already imagined. The tantric practice is the opposite of enforcing. You bring yourself. You bring the breath, the sound, the movement, the touch, the listening, the active and the receptive, the rhythm. You bring the question of what you actually want — today, in real time, in this body, with this person. You bring everything. Then you stop trying to design what happens next. What happens next emerges. Real bodies in real rooms don't follow scripts. They follow probability. Given everything in the room, something is going to happen, and there is a cloud of possibilities around what that something could be. The cloud is not a script. The cloud is the shape of what's likely, what's possible, what's available. The encounter will land somewhere inside the cloud. You don't get to pick where. You get to influence the shape of the cloud — by what you bring, by how you listen, by the rhythm you set, by your willingness to drop the script. You don't get to pick the spot inside it where the dart lands. The mystical traditions pointed at this with words like grace, like Tao, like the will of the divine. The pointing was true. An encounter between two open bodies feels purposeful even though no choreographer is running it. Call that grace if you want. Call it emergence if you want. The body knows the difference between the encounter that arrived on its own and the one you forced. You'll sometimes wonder how it knew exactly what you needed. It didn't know. You were the encounter. The encounter was you. The knowing was the emergence. Bring everything. Stop directing. Let the design emerge. The encounter is not what you make happen. The

encounter is what happens when you stop the making. What comes next is technique — every technique a configuration to bring into the field of possibility, not a script to enforce on the moment.

Part I — The Body You Live In

Chapter 1 — The Animal That You Are

You are an animal. A primate. A warm, breathing, upright primate that walked the African grass for a couple million years before it ever sat at a desk. Fire came late. Language, farming, cities — late. The screen, the stillness you're sitting in right now — that came in the last blink of an eye. The animal is what you are. Everything else is what we learned to lay on top. I was ten years old the first time I ran a meditation group. Weekly, in New York, in a room with grown adults sitting on the floor in it — and I picked the subjects. Pyramid power. Telekinesis. Any far-out thing I could get my hands around. The adults loved it. Nobody in that room was trying to get enlightened. We were doing it because it was interesting, and for everybody there that was reason enough. Then came the decades of chasing the thing people chase when they say enlightenment, freedom, peace — and I started where almost everyone starts: trying to get out of the body. Vipassana. Yoga. Twelve teachers across three continents. Breathwork until I saw colors, saw visions. Fasting. Eleven days without a word. The works. None of it landed the way the books promised. What woke me up was the opposite. Stop trying to leave. Sit down inside the thing. Look around. Feel what's actually moving in here. And what's in here is an animal. A fantastic, magical animal — far more than the culture ever let you believe. The culture told you the animal was the problem. The thing to manage, to repent, the thing dragging you toward hell. Your animal is not the problem. Your animal is the way through. So this is a walk through the equipment. The real equipment. The skin. The nerves. The gut. The breath. The sex organs, and the brain those organs are wired straight into. Sacred equipment — though nobody ever handed you the manual. Once you feel what's actually under the hood, the rest of this book opens on its own. Without it, even the most beautiful practice becomes one more instruction you follow in the dark, not knowing why your own

hands are moving. What I know about the animal, and the energies alive inside it, as plainly as I know how.

Evolution as the operating manual

The body you're sitting in was built by evolution. Not designed. Not gifted. Selected. The ancestors who didn't reproduce died without a line of progeny. The ones who fucked — a lot, with many, far past whoever they called a partner — those are the ones you came down from. Every one of them, all the way back. You are the cumulative settlement of millions of years of bodies that wanted each other badly enough to make more bodies. The shapes. The appetites. The fears. The way your heart speeds when you see something you want, and slows when you hold someone you love. All of it laid down across deep time by one quiet, relentless force: which bodies made more bodies. That sentence bothers some people. So I'm just an animal driven by reproduction? No. I'm saying the equipment was shaped by sex — by people who needed to fuck other people. What you do with the equipment now is yours. But running it well without knowing what it was built for is like using a car for a cereal bowl. Sure, you could. Why would you? You came from fuck. That's not crude — that's the plain fact of it. Fuck is what made you. And fuck is what built the cities, what drives the armies, what's underneath the wars. The whole churning thing runs on it. And then you get handed the big lie: that this — the very force that made you — is not a good thing. Something to be ashamed of. Sit with why anyone would teach you that. When you make a person's deepest drive into a thing to be ashamed of, you've found the hidden shame button on them. Shame is the lock somebody else holds the key to. Make a human ashamed of her own engine and you don't have to control the human — she'll do it for you. That's the trick. The drive was never the problem. The shame laid over it is the leash. Your body is an evolutionary product. Everything it does, it does because some version of doing it kept your

ancestors alive long enough to make you. The arousal. The desire. The bonding. The disgust. The reach for comfort. Old equipment, doing exactly what it was built to do — in a world that no longer looks anything like the one it was built from. And that's where the trouble lives. The shame, the worry about whether what you want is normal, the difficulty coming, the confusion about what you're even allowed to feel — almost all of it is ancient equipment running on a recent operating system. The body is millions of years old. The shame around it is a few thousand. Guess which one wins in the long run. Look at the timeline and it gets impossible to miss. For more than two hundred and fifty thousand years, sex just happened. No shame. No stories layered over it. No guilt, no fear, no permission slip required. People wanted each other and they came together, and that was the whole of it, for two hundred and fifty thousand years. Then the world changed. The stories arrived. The shame got installed — recently, on purpose, by people it served. We've been living inside that installation ever since, mistaking a few-thousand-year-old program for the truth of what we are. It's time to step out of it. Time to enter the age of sexual adulthood — to meet the oldest thing in us as grown people, without the guilt that was handed to us by someone who profited from the handing. And there's a reason it's the oldest thing, and the reason matters. Without sex there's no life. Not yours, not anyone's, not the whole long chain of bodies that produced you — every one of them came through it. Only the morality and the mythology pretend otherwise; the plain biology never did. Which means sex isn't one topic among many. It's the conduit the entire thing runs through — and you can't transcend the conduit of all life. People spend lifetimes trying to rise above it, and every road they take loops them straight back, because there's no above to get to. A principle everything else rests on isn't a preference you can opt out of. It's gravity. Drop the pen and it falls — not because the pen approves, but because that's the shape of the floor everything stands on. For a human body, sex is that floor. You don't transcend gravity. You learn to stand in it. And the

moment you stop fighting it and see it as the plain fact it is — not sacred, not dirty, just the ground — every bit of energy you'd been spending to rise above it comes back to you, free. We're not going to fight the body in this book. We're going to learn what it is, what it wants, and how to move with it — how to work with the energies already flowing through it. Working with what's already there: that's what tantra was, before the marketing got hold of it.

Why pleasure exists at all

Pleasure is information. You were probably taught it was a reward for being good, or a danger for being bad. Both wrong. Pleasure is the body telling you: this — whatever is happening right now — is something I was built to want more of. The food that tastes good tastes good because the ancestors who tasted similarly flavors and craved them, lived longer. The bodies you find beautiful look that way to you because the ancestors who responded to those bodies made more children. The touch that feels good feels good because the species needed that touch to keep its people alive. None of it is a mystery. All of it is old, and true, and yours. It runs on three lines. Survival. Sugar tastes good because sweet, ripe calories were rare. Sleep feels good because sleep does the repair that keeps you alive. Warmth feels good because cold is what took the ones who didn't go looking for the fire. Bonding. Touch from someone you trust releases the same chemistry a nursing baby releases. Sex floods you with bonding chemicals because the species needed people to stay close long enough to raise slowly developing children. The afterglow is real. It was built to be real. Signaling. Pleasure tells you what your body wants — your particular wiring — separate from what the culture told you to want. And the body's pleasure is older than the culture's instructions. When you light up around a certain person, a certain room, a certain sensation, that's reliable information about what you're calibrated to respond to. The signal is rarely wrong. What's

usually wrong is the shame somebody laid on top of it. Your body gives clear signals all day: what you want, what you do not, who to move toward, who to move away from, what feels alive, what feels dead. Most of us were trained to ignore them. Inappropriate. Not spiritual enough. Not what good people want. You are allowed to want what your body wants. What you do about it is a separate question, and we'll spend the rest of the book there. But the wanting itself is information, not sin. The body has been quietly telling you the truth this whole time. And there's a precise reason you stopped listening to it. The installation isn't only out there in the culture — it got wired into you, personally, one nervous system at a time. I feel good in my body got fused to something bad is going to happen — put that down, put that away. Two things that have nothing to do with each other, soldered together until they fire as one. The good feeling rises and the dread rises right behind it, automatic, faster than thought. That's not a flaw in you. Odds are, that's how you were taught. Nearly everyone got smacked down for their sexual energy at some point — a look, a word, a hand pulled away, a door that should've stayed open — and the wiring stuck. The pleasure and the punishment came in together, so now they travel together. That's the inherited block, and naming it precisely is the first step to pulling the two wires apart. If pleasure is information, then so is everything else — and any of it can be turned. Anything can be sexualized. Every sensation a body can have — every smell, every taste, every texture, the ones you reach for and the ones you may well have learned to flinch from — every one of them is raw charge, and raw charge can be routed. The disgust the culture handed you is not a wall. It's a strong energy with a lock on it, and a strong energy is exactly the kind you can turn into heat, into interest, into power. The body was never the problem. The sorting laid on top of it — this feeling is allowed, that one is dirty — that was the problem, and the sorting can come undone. Hold that as you read everything that follows: there is nothing the body feels that can't be turned around. That one fact opens the whole field.

The nervous system, in plain language

You have one nervous system, with two settings. The first is on. Heart faster. Pupils wide. Blood out to the muscles. Breath up high and shallow. The body readying to fight, to run, to lock onto a threat — or, sometimes, to chase something it wants. The textbooks call it sympathetic activation. Call it on. The second is open. Heart slows. Eyes soften. Blood moves back toward the gut and the genitals. Breath drops low and slow. This is the body digesting, healing, growing, repairing, bonding, getting curious, getting aroused, getting sleepy. The textbooks call it parasympathetic. People call it off — but off is the wrong word, because nearly all the good stuff lives here. Open is the truer name. Bodies move between on and open all day. Some moments call for one; some for the other. A body that can slide between them is doing well. Trouble starts when it gets stuck. And most adults are stuck in on. The switch jammed in the active position, the open side never getting its turn. It shows up as anxiety, insomnia, low desire, gut trouble, a short fuse, that nameless sense that something's wrong. A body running a half-marathon all day, every day, against an enemy that isn't there. Almost every practice in this book has the same quiet aim: bring the body back to open, on purpose, long enough that open starts to feel like home again. Breath does it. Sound does it. Slow movement does it. Touch from someone you trust does it. Sex done well does it. Ten minutes on the floor does it. Same destination, different roads. The reason so many of us have lost the thread of our own desire, our creativity, our appetite, our sleep, our patience, our plain joy — it's the same reason every time. The animal never gets back to open. It can't rest, can't digest, can't rise. It's standing guard against a threat that isn't coming. So most of what we do here is simple: we teach the animal the way back to open. And once you can find open on your own, on demand, most of what carried you to a book about tantra in the first place begins to loosen. Not all at once. But sooner than you'd think.

What “the body knows” means

You’ve heard it a thousand times. The body knows. Listen to your body. Your body has the answers. Said vaguely, it means nothing. Let me give it a body. You run on at least three real channels. The vagus nerve. A great nerve dropping from the base of the skull down through the chest and into the gut, carrying word from nearly every organ up to the brain. That gut feeling you get — it’s literal. A real signal traveling up the vagus, reporting on the food, the person across from you, the room you walked into. Not magic. Information. When something feels off about a person and you can’t say why, the vagus has usually caught what the thinking mind hasn’t gotten to yet — a flicker in the face, a smell, a gap between the words and the breath. Reliable often enough that ignoring it costs more than trusting it. Interoception — the body feeling its own inside. Hunger. Thirst. Arousal. Tension. Warmth. Fatigue. The small pressure that means you’ve been holding your breath. It’s how you know what’s happening in there. Most adults have gone faint on this one, and not by accident — they were trained out of it. Don’t eat now, you’ll spoil dinner. You can’t be tired, it’s only nine. You’re not hungry, you just ate. The override voices get loud, the body’s voice goes quiet, and by their thirties a lot of people genuinely can’t tell hungry from tired from aroused from bored. Nearly every practice in this book is, underneath, a way of turning that channel back up. You get quiet. You notice what the body’s doing. You stop telling it what it should feel, and start asking what it does feel — and you let the answer rise to where you can read it. Proprioception — the body knowing where it is in space. Where your arm is with your eyes closed. How far the knee is bent. What lets you walk down dark stairs, or find your nose without a mirror. It runs constantly, just under awareness. Sharpen it and a lot improves — movement, balance, healing — and one that doesn’t get talked about: pleasure. A body that knows where it is can feel itself touched more precisely. A body gone numb to where it is has usually

gone numb to sensation, period. Bring proprioception back and you bring back the capacity to feel. So the body knows turns out to be true and specific. Three channels — vagus, interoception, proprioception. All three carry real information. All three can be grown. And all three are what tantra has been training all along, even back when the tradition called it by other names.

You are an animal — created by evolution to want, feel, signal, and respond. Two settings, on and open, and most of us get stuck in the on position. Three channels of knowing — vagus, interoception, proprioception — reporting the truth of what's happening inside you, underneath whatever the mind's been told to think. The rest of this book is the manual for the equipment. The next six chapters form a cycle: breath, sound, movement, touch, stillness, receiving, and then back to breath. Each one a road back to open, each one a way to switch the body's knowing back on. You don't have to believe anything. You don't have to take on a worldview. You need a body. You're already holding one. You'll feel things you haven't felt in a while — and a few you may never have felt clearly before. That's the deal.

That was the beginning.

The full book is 620 pages: breath, sound, touch, anatomy, orgasm, meditation, the 112 practices, the history, avoiding the cult, and daily practice.

The Definitive Guide to Modern Tantra
by Lawrence Lanoff

tantra-authority.com/the-definitive-guide